

For His Name, in Love

On Intention, Love, and Will

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Translator's Note on Key Terms

This translation preserves several Hebrew and Aramaic terms whose religious, legal, or kabbalistic resonance would be flattened by a single English equivalent. Their first appearances are glossed in context; the following renderings are used consistently throughout:

- **Torah she-bikhtav** — the Written Torah.
- **Torah she-be'al peh** — the Oral Torah.
- **halakhah** — the binding corpus and practice of Jewish law.
- **tzimtzum** — contraction or self-limitation.
- **or** — light; the divine content or influx.
- **keli / kelim** — vessel / vessels; the human forms through which divine content is received.
- **lishmah** — for its own sake; with no ulterior end.
- **shelo lishmah** — not for its own sake.
- **leshem Shamayim** — for the sake of Heaven.
- **avodah** — divine service.
- **kabbalat ol malkhut Shamayim** — acceptance of the yoke of the Kingdom of Heaven.

One of the central foundations of Jewish moral teaching is the demand that we purify our hearts and intentions and direct them toward God alone. The intention accompanying an act is of decisive significance; it can turn the value of an act from good to bad, and from negative to blessed. In Mesillat Yesharim, the term “a pure heart” comes to mean “an intention without ulterior motives”: a state in which a person’s actions are performed solely with the unalloyed intention of *leshem Shamayim*—for the sake of Heaven—cleansed of lower and alien desires.

Two levels can be distinguished in the demand to refine intention. On the first level—by no means a simple one—the concern is the intention present while performing religious acts. When a person puts on tefillin, studies Torah, or fulfills a commandment, he must make an effort to focus his attention upon the positive aim of doing God’s will alone. The inner struggle at this stage is the attempt to uproot from the heart alien motives and lower desires that may mingle with its inward movement when one approaches the performance of God’s word: the pursuit of honor and self-image, social standing, or material gain.

At a still higher level, the demand is to refine the entire orientation of life, in all its details and deeds: “Let all your actions be for the sake of Heaven.” Even actions that are not sacred and do not fulfill an explicit divine command must be intended toward the end of serving God. When a person eats, he must rise above the natural-material desire merely to satisfy hunger and impress upon his heart the religious purpose of the act: eating in order to remain alive, in order to fulfill God’s commandments. Unlike the previous demand, this one has weighty consequences not only for intention but also for action. Deeds that cannot find an honest justification within a chain of purposes leading toward divine service lose their legitimacy and come to be classified as “problematic” or “negative,” as acts opposed to God’s will.

In both cases, however, we are speaking about the same intention, the same inward feeling meant to accompany the act. In this essay I wish to investigate and clarify something of the nature of that feeling or inward intention.

At first glance, an intention *leshem Shamayim* sounds clear, self-evident, almost trivial, and not in need of extended analysis. Yet on a second and third look, when we try to bring it down into the concrete and existential realm, the fog surrounding it becomes too thick for the concept to be of real use.

One way to characterize an inward intention is through contrast and fine separation. To illustrate, I will use the words of Rabbi Moshe Hayyim Luzzatto, the Ramhal:

Wholeness of heart means that one’s service before the Blessed One be performed with purity of intention—that is, for the sole purpose of serving Him and for no other motive. This also includes that one’s heart be whole in the service, not like one who wavers between two sides, nor like one who performs “a commandment of men learned by rote,” but that his whole heart be given to it.

Introduction to Mesillat Yesharim

The Ramhal attempts to define the desired wholeness of heart and purity of intention, yet in practice half the sentence is devoted to possible alternatives: no other motive, no wavering between two sides, no rote performance. Psychological concepts are clarified more sharply through comparison and contrast, and perception is refined by subtle analytic distinctions among different psychic powers.

Accordingly, to characterize properly the pure and desirable motive called *leshem Shamayim*, we must clarify precisely how it differs in essence from other intentions, whether natural or negative. To do so I will take one further step backward and examine the concept of “intention” in general.

II

When we explain human motivation, we use two parallel systems of explanation that coexist side by side: cause and effect, and means and end. My desire to eat an apple can, for example, be explained through physiological descriptions of stimulation and neural signaling to the brain. In this way one constructs a chain of causes culminating in an impulse to act. This is the usual scientific explanation, in medicine and physiology as well as psychology. In everyday life, by contrast, we generally use a purposive explanation: we choose to eat the apple in order to become full, so that we can continue the day and attend to other matters. What generates the chain is precisely its final, foreknown outcome—the end.

The Torah sources relevant to our subject—intention in *avodat Hashem* and the purification of the will *leshem Shamayim*—also divide according to these two systems, causal and teleological. Some sources require that the orientation of action not be low and personal gain but a general, divine “gain”: do not act in order to receive reward; do not make Torah a spade with which to dig; act to repair the world under the sovereignty of the Almighty; act to bring satisfaction to the Creator; act for the sake of the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His *Shekhinah*. All these formulations address the end and inward direction of the act. Alongside them are sources that, at first glance, seem unrelated, yet demand the refinement of the hidden motive, the source of religious motivation. One must do truth because it is truth; one may act from fear and awe of God, or instead from love of God; from natural morality and uprightness; from rote habit, or instead through a special intention *leshem Shamayim*, from *devekut* and religious ardor. These formulations ask not “for what end?” but “because of what do you act—what force moved you?”

III

Let us first examine the teleological way of depicting pure intention *leshem Shamayim* through a familiar example: eating for the sake of Heaven. Musar teaching calls us to eat with religious intention—to remember and internalize that the aim of eating is solely to preserve our basic existence, to eat in order to live. Why live? Not from an egoistic wish to realize the instinct for life, but in order to fulfill the divine command, keep the commandments, and serve our Creator, which is possible only in life. Yet once we employ the concept of an end, an image automatically arises of a causal chain of outcomes, and attention turns to the last outcome in the chain, which can be defined as the act’s purpose. A teleological explanation of motivation asks: What is the

gain? What outcome do I seek and intend? The intellect is therefore driven to the unavoidable question: Why fulfill the divine command? What is intended by it; what is the gain, the end?

At this point two directions of answer stand before us, egoistic and non-egoistic. Egoistic answers concerning the purpose of serving God refer to various forms of reward: a feeling of self-perfection, eternal life in the World to Come, or rescue from the judgment of Gehinnom. The difficulty is that we seem thereby to lose the “purity” and ethical character of the intention. If the final purpose underlying the action is private, egocentric gain, we have apparently missed *leshem Shamayim*. The act is not for Heaven or any other sacred aim, but for yourself and your private welfare, and it possesses no special sublimity or ethical superiority.

If we wish to preserve the notion of a pure intention *leshem Shamayim*, we must therefore answer the question of the purpose of divine service in a non-egoistic way. A common answer is: “in order to bring satisfaction to the Creator.” Yet this example only heightens the difficulty. The answer touches us, and we feel that it faithfully describes a real difference between flawed and pure intention; but on the philosophical-rational plane it has no intelligible meaning. We cannot conceive of “gain” or “satisfaction” of any kind in relation to God. We know in advance that the words have no referent, and thus—contrary to our elementary existential feeling—the answer lacks meaning for the intellect.

Another non-egoistic answer is general and eschatological: I fulfill Torah and commandments for the good of the whole, to benefit all existence and bring it to complete redemption. This answer is rationally intelligible; it explains why such an intention differs ethically from one that is not *leshem Shamayim*. The essential distinction would then be between an end of private, egoistic gain and an end of general, non-egoistic benefit.

IV

Here, however, I wish to reach the root of the difficulty in teleological explanation as such, not only in religious intention. When we look deeply into ourselves while asking the questions raised above, is our attention really turned outward toward the objective benefit produced by the acts, or inward toward the desires and psychic forces that drive us? What gives the difference between egoistic and non-egoistic intention its genuine ethical content: the real difference between intended ends and outcomes, or the psychological experience of the difference between a selfish motive and a gracious, altruistic motive? I have no doubt that the true focus of ethical inquiry into intention is the causal, motivating psychic force.

Our distinction between a noble and a base motive, or a “higher” and “lower” motive, is intuitive. It exists not merely as a linguistic convention but as a real, nonverbal psychic content. Does our judgment that altruistic intention is positive and moral rest upon examining the consequences and inferring that, because these acts produced more important real-world benefit, the intention behind them should be called ethical? Does our judgment that egoistic intention is lower arise from contemplating its practical consequences? I believe the answer is unequivocally no. The inward, intuitive recognition of the purity or sublimity of altruistic intention is *a priori*. It arises from inward contemplation of the soul’s chambers and its motivating powers. The causal

system therefore gives the most candid and exact description of the formation of will and action.

This also explains the feeling of being intellectually “stuck” when analyzing the intention to bring satisfaction to the Creator. The gap between the existential feeling that intention for God contains real content and our inability to translate that content into rationally meaningful language of purpose and gain arises because, in ontological truth, intentions are rooted in different motives rather than different ends. To describe will as arising from a purpose—that is, from an outcome of the act—does not truly capture its source. The source is always some force or point in the psyche that, by its own nature, pushes the person in a particular direction.

A further paradox follows from teleological language. Every answer to the question “for what?” can be met by the same question again. Why make coffee? To drink it. Why drink it? To feel less tired. Why wish to feel less tired? To concentrate on studying for an examination. The chain can continue until it reaches an end at which teleological language stalls: no further “for what” can be supplied; this is the thing itself, what I want and for the sake of which I act. If we continue pressing the intellect, we shift into causal-motivational explanation. Asked why we want to live, eat something tasty, or experience pleasure, we finally appeal to the instinct for life, appetite, or the psychic pleasure principle. I desire food because a hunger instinct within me moves me to eat. That instinct is the source and cause of my desire, and no further purposive explanation can be added.

V

Our conclusion thus far is that teleological explanation of will contains a fundamental falsification, and that the only system that truly explains will is the causal one. Why, then, did teleological language for action and will arise, and what sustains it despite this falsification?

It exists because we experience ourselves as free agents—and we are free—while choice has meaning only when our acts are detached from a chain of prior causes. Human logic and rational language, however, cannot relinquish causal chains, since sensory experience knows no uncaused phenomenon and comprehension requires that events be linked within such a system. A deep contradiction therefore appears between the causal regularity underlying human cognition, shaped by the phenomenal world, and the person’s decisive a priori certainty of free choice. To escape this cognitive entanglement, the human mind invents an inverted causal system. Its chain runs not from a first cause to a future effect, but from the anticipated future consequences of a present act back to the act itself. If I regard a free act as a beginning yet must still speak of it in causal language, I can only view it as the effect of an end—as moved by its foreseen result. I explain my will and deeds by pointing to their direction and consequence. Thus they acquire meaning rather than remaining arbitrary, chaotic events. Human beings weave the meaning of action and will through the result toward which they lead.

Every concept connected with choice—morality, divine command, goodness, and the like—must therefore speak teleologically. Ethical language evaluates an act by its consequences because this is the only accessible way to measure freely chosen acts. An act is judged moral according to whether it adds good to reality or brings well-being

to another. Every ethical vision rests upon a goal or direction toward which the world should be led, and present acts are judged in relation to that future.

VI

Once we have spoken of the causality that moves human action, we cannot avoid free will. If the encounter between freedom of the will and causality produces a felt contradiction, that contradiction requires a philosophical answer. If causality as known in nature is accepted as the sole and total principle, no room remains for belief in freedom. Just as, theoretically, every factor producing rainfall can be analyzed, so could every factor producing a human action be analyzed and the action predicted in advance. In a given situation the person would have no liberty; behavior would be dictated by human motives and the laws governing them.

The answer, it seems, is that even if every given result has a definite cause, it does not follow that a definite cause must always lead to one determinate result. Many different causes and motives operate within a person. We may imagine that in the passage from a situation to its outcome there is an aperture that freely selects which motives will produce the future, which will be rejected or blocked, and to what degree. The data do not dictate the human result. Every situation contains several possible continuations, dependent upon the point of choice within the person.

On this account, causality is preserved only on one side. Every result has a cause, but it is not necessary that every cause produce its possible result, or that a particular real situation have only one necessary outcome.

The inner event can therefore be pictured as follows. Different motivating forces live within the person, each pushing in a different direction and toward different acts. Each motive has its basic vector. Freedom is the capacity to choose which motives will proceed and shape the will that becomes actual in reality. The point of choice lies precisely in the transition from the physiological-psychic-spiritual unconscious into conscious thought and will. We may now return to intention leshem Shamayim.

VII

Maimonides writes in his introduction to the chapter Helek:

The sages, peace be upon them, warned us against this, saying: "Do not make them a crown with which to aggrandize yourself, nor a spade with which to dig." They meant what I have explained: one should not make the purpose of study the honor of other people or the acquisition of wealth, nor make the Torah of the Lord a livelihood. The sole purpose of study should be knowledge itself. Likewise, the purpose of truth is only to know that it is true; and the commandments are true, and therefore their purpose is their fulfillment...

This is the statement of the perfect pious man who apprehended truth, Antigonus of Sokho: "Do not be like servants who serve the master in order to receive a reward, but like servants who serve the master not in order to receive a reward." They intended thereby that one should affirm truth for the sake of truth itself, and this is what is called one who serves from love. They also said: "He greatly delights in His commandments"—Rabbi Elazar said: in His commandments, and not in the reward of

His commandments... Greater still is their statement in the Sifrei: "Perhaps you will say: I will study Torah so that I may become wealthy, so that I may be called Rabbi, so that I may receive reward in the World to Come. Scripture therefore says, 'to love the Lord': whatever you do, do only from love." This matter has thus been explained and clarified: it is the aim of the commandments and the foundation of the sages' faith...

This was the degree of Abraham our father, who served from love, and toward this path one is obligated to strive. Yet the sages knew that this matter is exceedingly difficult and not everyone can attain it; and even one who attains it may not find it plausible at first, since the human way is to act in order to obtain some benefit or prevent some harm, otherwise the act appears futile... They therefore permitted the multitude to remain in their outlook, doing good in hope of reward and avoiding evil from fear of punishment, encouraging and strengthening them in this thought until the one capable of apprehension attains and knows the truth and the perfect way... The multitude do not lose everything by fulfilling the commandments from fear of punishment and hope of reward; they are merely incomplete. It is better for them to do so until they acquire the disposition and training to fulfill Torah, pass over to truth, and serve from love. This is what the sages meant by saying: "A person should always engage in Torah even shelo lishmah, for from shelo lishmah one comes to lishmah."

Maimonides, Commentary on the Mishnah, Sanhedrin, ch. 10

Maimonides combines several Talmudic terms into a single meaning. He links "a spade with which to dig," "in order to receive reward," and shelo lishmah, and sets them as the negative image of the intention proper to a perfected person in divine service, observance, and Torah study.

Especially striking is his identification of "not in order to receive reward," or lishmah, with being an oved me-ahavah—one who serves from love. This identification is not self-evident and deserves attention.

The difference between these expressions lies precisely in our earlier distinction. "Do not be like servants who serve the master in order to receive reward" examines intention teleologically: what end lies at the foundation of attention in acting? Service from love, by contrast, describes the inward psychological-emotional movement that leads and drives the person toward an act. Elsewhere it is contrasted with service from fear; it concerns the quality of experience and the character of the psychic movement toward action. The focus is not the rationale beneath the act but the general force that moves the person.

It is also significant that Maimonides gives "service from love" no concrete teleological equivalent. He offers only a negation of service for reward: not in order to receive reward, not for the reward of the commandments. The distinction is not between one purpose and another. Pure intention, lishmah, is defined as an intention for which no end whatever can be pointed out.

To close the circle and explain the essential bond among love, leshem Shamayim, and the absence of purpose, I will briefly examine the experience of love.

VIII

Rivers of ink and paint have been poured out to portray love. I do not propose to encompass the concept or imprison it in a definition. I will address only one aspect essential here: egocentricity and love.

A familiar witticism tells of a man asked, "Do you love fish?" "Certainly," he replied. The questioner answered cleverly: "If you love fish, how can you eat them?"

Many, especially in the rabbinic world, use this saying to expose what they see as corrupted or mistaken love in Western culture. Romantic love, marked by an inundation of powerful feeling, is criticized in religious-Zionist rabbinic discourse for its transience, which conflicts with building a stable home; for excessive sensuality and emotionality, at odds with the settled rational character Torah seeks to form; and for its hedonistic dimension, held to be fundamentally opposed to the Jewish world of values.

Pleasure undoubtedly occupies a large place in modern Western images of love. Popular arts—literature and cinema—depict the encounter with love as a supreme, happy, harmonious time. Its pleasure justifies entering commitment and relationship and motivates the search for love and the important place granted it in life. Love's "value" is thus measured not only in ethical but also in hedonic categories. The criticism is that this preoccupation with emotional-psychic pleasure casts a shadow over, and threatens, the ethical purity of "true love," defined through grace, care, and giving.

This criticism begins from the assumption that love must in essence be altruistic. Every touch of selfishness, personal gain, or pursuit of pleasure within love's emotional complex diminishes it and indicates falsity or at least imperfection. Absolute love is interest-free. It exceeds the ego and goes outside the self. The person seeks no return or enjoyment, and any such aspiration, even hidden and nondominant, contradicts the basic essence of being loving.

The problem lies in the vagueness of the concept of egoism. We all intuit that one who sees only his own enjoyment in every encounter with the beloved, while wholly ignoring the will and requests of the person with whom he is related, does not truly love. A love containing no wish to benefit the other or bring the other joy cannot be called love, however much the lover enjoys the beloved's company. But must every experience of personal pleasure contradict pure love, with its *hesed* and desire for the other's good?

Here we encounter a general philosophical problem concerning egoism and pleasure. Egoism cannot be defined by the amount of pleasure a person receives from an act, because pleasure is, by definition, the result of a fulfilled will. Every realization of desire brings some pleasure. Pleasures differ in emotional quality and spiritual-moral level: the pleasure of watching a film is unlike that of reading a compelling work of thought, pure prayer, eating delicious food, or giving charity. Each realizes a different psychic longing, and the satisfaction differs greatly. Yet ultimately will and pleasure are two sides of one coin. To say that I desire something is to say that fulfilling it would give me some pleasure, and conversely. If every desire involving pleasure is egoistic, no non-egoistic desire can exist.

We might still define as egoistic a desire whose dominant motive is pleasure. This assumes a model in which basic motivating forces mingle and combine into concrete desires directed toward particular objects in real contexts. Every conscious desire is a mixture of these forces, and introspection may attempt to estimate the relative “quantity” of each within it.

Even on this model, however, the human being would almost be imprisoned within egoism. Deep examination would reveal pleasure—spiritual, material, moral, social, or otherwise—behind everything one does. This does not make every act base. A person seeking complete self-repair and refinement of character is moved in part by an image of perfection that gives pleasure, and that image and pleasure generate the will to perfection. This motive is sincere, deep, and highly spiritual, yet it still revolves around a non-altruistic point grounded in personal pleasure.

IX

Why did I say “almost”? Because among human motives there are some that exceed the simple pleasure principle. Such is the power of love, or more generally the power of hesed. Hesed names the one motive that causes us to exceed ourselves, break through the circle of selfishness, and direct ourselves toward another. It is an absurd motive, unable to explain itself clearly to the psyche. Hesed makes a leap from an inward language that knows only self-pleasure and fulfillment, from egocentricity encompassing all fields of psyche and will, toward a strange kind of desire in which there is will without pleasure, or at least pleasure is not its fundamental generator. It is a will existing for itself, like a foreign shoot in the soul, pushing the person toward acts without a logic of profit.

We can bring this power closer to understanding through the concept of identification. Hesed involves an exchange of identity, the extension of one’s selfhood over the other through identification. The person expands—or rather leaps—and feels his own selfhood within the other; his will becomes equal to the other’s will, so that he desires the other’s good and pleasure as though it were his own. Hesed often brings sweetness and delight, but we can sense that this enjoyment does not generate the desire for the other’s good; it only adds an external encouragement. In ordinary hesed, without special conscious intention, the pleasure received by the agent is relatively dim, since all the act’s benefit is directed toward the other. Pleasure plays its role only after, in the inwardness of the soul, the person has left the narrow shoes of selfhood and entered, through identification, the shoes and interests of the other.

This allows us to distinguish hesed from love. They clearly share the capacity to exceed the narrow self through identification. Yet hesed is a complete departure from the circle of self-interest, whereas love expands that circle and brings another inside it. Love unites selfhood and transcendence. Its wonder—the reason it resembles madness, the reason it is so irrational despite its reality and certainty—lies in its capacity to contain a leap outward together with pleasure and fulfillment, inseparably joining selfhood, abundance, and harmony with hesed, ex-centricity, and non-egoistic excess. Love is non-selfish selfhood. Its identification does not replace the “I” with the “other,” but unites them, equalizing will and interest. I desire the other’s good in exactly the sense in which I desire my own; the other’s pleasure or fulfilled will causes pleasure in me as well.

There can be no real separation between love's altruistic side and its personal pleasure. To demand that love be purified of every selfish touch, or to argue that the desire to enjoy love compromises its truth as a non-egoistic essence, is to fail to recognize love's nature: the unity of the tendency toward *hesed* with the tendency toward selfhood.

X

Love means aspiring to become one with the beloved. Its psychic-ontological root can be understood in light of the metaphysical picture called monism, in which existence ultimately subsists in a single, unitary point. In its Jewish-kabbalistic version, this joins the view called panentheism: all is within divinity, and God is one; therefore all is one within divinity. What matters here is the implication for the soul. The soul may be pictured as a ladder of many layers, whose poles are, on one side, ego, separateness, and individual selfhood, and on the other, the all-inclusive ontic unity, the root of all being—ultimately God. Layers deeper than the ego, which expresses the person's particular and unique identity, also lie beyond the ordinary reach of consciousness and feeling. They are the person's circles of belonging: couple, family, tribe, nation, humanity, world, existence. Love arises from the capacity to identify with a point of depth in the soul, a layer more rooted than private individuality. The person touches that abyssal point at which the soul exits selfishness and is only a spark of an encompassing spiritual-ontic sphere; from there comes its desire to become one with that sphere again. From there love grows.

Rabbi Akiva offers an illustration:

Though only as a drop of water from the sea, a single spark from a flame reaching the heart of heaven, one letter from a vast and broad book, a man whose soul was so exalted also knew how to value natural personal love in its purity. Pure natural love, enlightened national love, and holy divine love filled with majesty were ordered within him in one array, like the Tower of David built with turrets.

Olat Re'iyah II, p. 3

The passage comes from Rabbi Abraham Isaac Kook's introduction to the Song of Songs. He explains why Rabbi Akiva, specifically, emphasized the scroll's stature to the point of declaring that all the Scriptures are holy, but the Song of Songs is the Holy of Holies. Rabbi Akiva's figure is conspicuous for its capacity for love: his extraordinary love for his wife, the daughter of Kalba Savua; his teaching that "You shall love your neighbor as yourself" is a great principle of Torah; his devotion to the nation, extending according to some accounts to serving Bar Kokhba in the revolt against Rome; and at the end of his life, his self-sacrifice in fulfilling "You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might."

Rav Kook's special conception appears in his description of these planes of love as one "Tower of David built with turrets." The capacity to love is fundamentally one capacity arising from a single rooted point in the psyche. Love can fasten upon objects at different levels, but its power is the same. One who habituates, trains, and directs himself toward love becomes a loving person at the root. The division among the different objects of love—the levels of that tower—is then more quantitative than essential. This reconnects with the soul as an ontological ladder whose base is God

and whose outermost upper story is the individual ego. The essential gift of love is the descent into the soul's ontological depths and identification with them.

XI

We can now tie the strands together.

Love is a will without an end. The reason underlying my desire to benefit my beloved or fulfill the beloved's will cannot be translated into teleological language, the language of gain, because that language is immersed in the egoistic circle. Unlike other motives that permit teleological explanation, when we look inward and face the motive of love we can only acknowledge its existence in itself, without finding a rational cause or explanation. I desire my beloved's good simply because I desire it. The will cannot be anchored in anything beyond the will itself.

When we seek an ethical intention, an intention *leshem Shamayim*, we seek an intention that leaves coarse selfishness and exceeds narrow, profitable egoistic desires. We therefore find that the best way to describe the pure motive whose object is God and the good is through the motive called love. This is not merely a borrowed metaphor. The same power of love that enables us to break the boundaries of narrow selfhood and intend ourselves for another, solely for that other, can take an abstract object such as the good or God. Just as I can act for my beloved after identifying with the beloved and therefore with the beloved's "interests" and desires—an identification possible from the deep root of the soul where it is truly one with the other—so can I relate to God. Since we believe the soul to be a part of God above, directing love toward God or the good has real and literal meaning. It is the same power that leads us out of separateness and egocentric enclosure toward identification with another human being. More than that: this is the only possible meaning of a pure intention, free of ulterior motives and profitable interests—an intention *leshem Shamayim*.

Notes

1. This basic distinction, which locates the ethical difference in egoism versus non-egoism, remains in force through the essay's conclusion, though the concept of egoism itself will be refined.
2. A priori means prior to experience: an insight present in the psyche not as the result of empirical experiment or external observation.
3. The background is Kant's distinction between phenomena and things-in-themselves, or noumena. Causality belongs inseparably to the phenomenal realm, while freedom is rooted in the noumenal.
4. The epistemological origin of teleological vision does not render it meaningless. In Kantian terms, meaning belongs to phenomena. Teleological ends are not ontologically the sources of motivation, but they clothe and represent genuine differences among causal motives.
5. Such a theory can neither be proved nor disproved unless one presupposes that rigid natural causality applies in precisely the same way to human freedom—an assumption opposed to elementary existential experience and not obligatory.
6. The fish witticism is associated with the Israeli comedy trio Ha-Gashash Ha-Hiver.
7. For a fuller account of rabbinic criticism of Western romantic love and a critique of that criticism, see Itamar Brenner, "Marriage-Guidance Literature," in *Va-Yikra et Shemam Adam* (Binah La-Ittim Institute, 5765), pp. 273–282; and Rabbi Itai Mor-Yosef, "On Religious-Zionist Couple Culture: Rationality, Sanctity, and Romance," *ibid.*, pp. 260–261.
8. The distinction between hesed and love is developed below.
9. The account of hesed as leaving the self and identifying with another is not proposed as a consciously experienced process, but as a theoretical account of its hidden ontological structure beneath awareness.
10. Identification does not return hesed to egoism. The freely chosen leap into identification with the other is itself the departure from selfishness and the ethical meaning of altruism: among the motives available within us, one chooses the motive of hesed over others.
11. Erich Fromm similarly describes mature love as union under the condition that each person's integrity and individuality remain, culminating in the paradox of two beings who become one and nevertheless remain two (*The Art of Loving*, pp. 27–28 in the cited Hebrew edition).
12. In Hebrew gematria, ahavah, "love," has the same numerical value as ehad, "one."
13. The couple is treated here as a spiritual entity in its own right. Genesis 5:1–2 names male and female together "Adam." Rabbinic and Platonic myths of the primordial androgyne likewise portray love as a longing to reunite with the other half from which one was separated.
14. Mishnah Yadayim 3:5.
15. See Ketubot 62b.
16. Sifra, Kedoshim, section 2, chapter 4.
17. See Berakhot 61b.
18. Rav Kook is not alone in this account of love's nature. Related directions appear in Plato's *Symposium* and, explicitly, in Erich Fromm, especially pp. 48–49 of the cited edition.